

Digital rights

In a **landmark ruling** last week, the Supreme Court of India has declared digital access a fundamental right, **affirming** its **intrinsic** link to the right to life, education, expression, and equality. This **judgment** (**clubbing** *Pragya Prasun vs Union of India and Amar Jain vs Union of India*) **is** timely and **far-sighted**. However, **turning** universal digital access into a ground reality **entails** **grappling with** structural, legal, and economic challenges.

The ruling rightly **acknowledges** that the internet is a basic **enabler** of education, employment, governance, and social inclusion. Whether it's accessing welfare schemes, applying for jobs, studying online, or simply **exercising** free speech, connectivity defines 21st-century citizenship. Yet, India's digital **landscape** remains deeply unequal in various ways. The **starkest** is the rural-urban gap. While cities may **boast** improved connectivity, **vast swathes** of rural India grapple with **non-existent** or unreliable networks, slow speeds, and inadequate **infrastructure**. The **digital divide** is more than a connectivity issue — it is an exclusion issue. It **reinforces** the **marginalisation** of communities who are already underserved **in terms of** education, healthcare, and infrastructure. Therefore, the top court's **recognition** of digital access as a right **must** be followed by policy action that bridges this divide.

The first challenge is to **scale up** broadband infrastructure, particularly in rural and underserved regions. While programmes like BharatNet have made progress, they remain **hampered** by delays, funding **bottlenecks**, and implementation gaps. **The Universal Service Obligation Fund** (USOF), meant to finance rural connectivity, **must** be **overhauled** and **deployed** more efficiently. Second, **affordability** is key. Recognising the internet as a right is **hollow** if people cannot afford data plans or devices. The government must work with telecom companies to ensure low-cost broadband tariffs, subsidised data plans for low-income households, and **affordable** smartphones or tablets, especially for students and small entrepreneurs. Public Wi-Fi initiatives and community digital centres can serve as short-term measures in high-need areas. Third, there is the issue of digital **literacy**. **Millions of Indians**, especially women and the elderly, **lack** the skills to **navigate** digital platforms securely. Public education campaigns and **grassroots** digital literacy programmes must become a national priority if the court's vision is to be fulfilled. **[Practice Exercise]**



- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

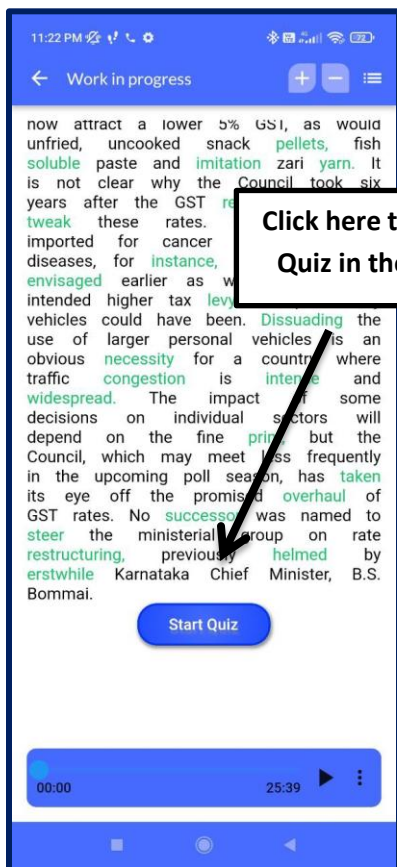
1. **Landmark** (adjective) – historic, significant, pivotal, momentous, trailblazing ऐतिहासिक
2. **Ruling** (noun) – judgment, decision, verdict, decree, resolution निर्णय
3. **Affirm** (verb) – declare, assert, confirm, uphold, support पुष्टि करना
4. **Intrinsic** (adjective) – inherent, innate, essential, fundamental, natural स्वाभाविक
5. **Club** (verb) – combine, merge, group, consolidate, unify एक साथ मिलाना
6. **Far-sighted** (adjective) – visionary, foresighted, prudent, perceptive, wise दूरदर्शी
7. **Entail** (verb) – involve, require, necessitate, demand, include आवश्यक बनाना
8. **Grapple** (with) (verb) – struggle, wrestle, tackle, confront, deal जूझना
9. **Acknowledge** (verb) – recognize, accept, admit, affirm, appreciate स्वीकार करना
10. **Enabler** (noun) – facilitator, promoter, supporter, catalyst, initiator सहायक
11. **Exercise** (verb) – use, apply, implement, exert, employ प्रयोग करना
12. **Landscape** (noun) – scenario, environment, terrain, setting, structure परिदृश्य
13. **The Starkest** (noun) – the most extreme, harshest, clearest, most obvious, most striking सबसे तीव्र या स्पष्ट
14. **Boast** (verb) – claim, flaunt, brag, show off, possess डोंग मारना / गर्व से कहना
15. **Vast** (adjective) – immense, extensive, huge, enormous, expansive विशाल
16. **Swathe** (noun) – stretch, area, belt, strip, region चौड़ा क्षेत्र
17. **Non-existent** (adjective) – absent, missing, unavailable, lacking, null अस्तित्वहीन
18. **Infrastructure** (noun) – framework, facilities, systems, foundation, setup आधारभूत संरचना
19. **Digital divide** (noun) – the gulf between those who have ready access to computers and the internet, and those who do not.
20. **Reinforce** (verb) – strengthen, support, bolster, cement, affirm सुदृढ़ करना
21. **Marginalisation** (noun) – treatment of a person, group, or concept as insignificant or peripheral. हाशिये पर डालना
22. **In terms of** (phrase) – regarding, concerning, with respect to, relating to, from the point of view of के संदर्भ में

23. **Scale up** (phrasal verb) – expand, enlarge, increase, boost, intensify विस्तार करना
24. **Hamper** (verb) – hinder, obstruct, impede, delay, restrict बाधा डालना
25. **Bottleneck** (noun) – obstacle, blockage, hurdle, choke point, constraint रुकावट
26. **Overhaul** (verb) – revamp, reform, restructure, improve, renovate सुधार करना
27. **Deploy** (verb) – utilize, implement, activate, put in place, apply तैनात करना
28. **Affordability** (noun) – cost-effectiveness, reasonableness, accessibility, price feasibility, budget-friendliness वहन करने की क्षमता
29. **Hollow** (adjective) – empty, meaningless, superficial, false, insincere खोखला
30. **Affordable** (adjective) – inexpensive, economical, reasonable, low-cost, budget सस्ती
31. **Literacy** (noun) – education, knowledge, learning, proficiency, competence साक्षरता
32. **Navigate** (verb) – operate, manage, steer, handle, browse रास्ता निकालना / चलाना
33. **Grassroots** (noun) – base level, common people, foundation, local community, ground level जमीनी स्तर

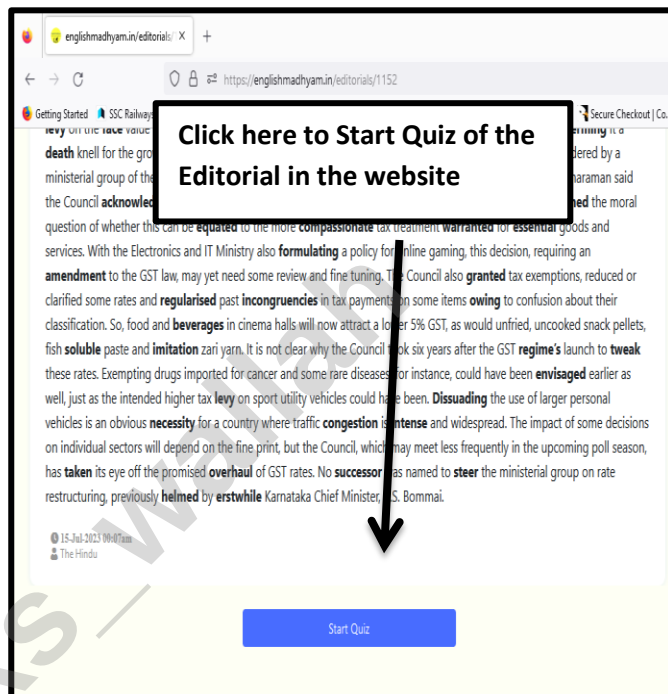
Summary of the Editorial

1. The Supreme Court of India has declared digital access a fundamental right, linking it to life, education, expression, and equality.
2. The judgment combines two cases — Pragma Prasun vs Union of India and Amar Jain vs Union of India — and is seen as timely and visionary.
3. The Court recognized the internet as a basic enabler of education, employment, governance, and social inclusion.
4. Digital access is essential for exercising citizenship in the 21st century, from applying for jobs to accessing welfare and expressing opinions.
5. India faces a deep digital divide, especially between urban and rural areas.
6. Rural regions suffer from poor or non-existent connectivity, slow speeds, and weak digital infrastructure.
7. The digital divide is not just technological — it is an issue of exclusion and inequality, especially for already underserved communities.
8. The Court's recognition must now be matched by robust policy action to reduce this divide.
9. The first challenge is improving broadband infrastructure, especially in rural and remote areas.
10. Projects like BharatNet have shown promise but face delays and funding challenges.
11. The Universal Service Obligation Fund (USOF), intended to boost rural connectivity, needs to be restructured and better utilized.
12. Affordability is a critical issue; access is meaningless if people can't afford data or digital devices.
13. The government should partner with telecom firms to offer low-cost tariffs, subsidized data, and affordable devices.
14. Short-term solutions include public Wi-Fi spots and community digital centres in underserved areas.
15. Finally, digital literacy—especially for women and the elderly—must be made a national priority through education and grassroots campaigns.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



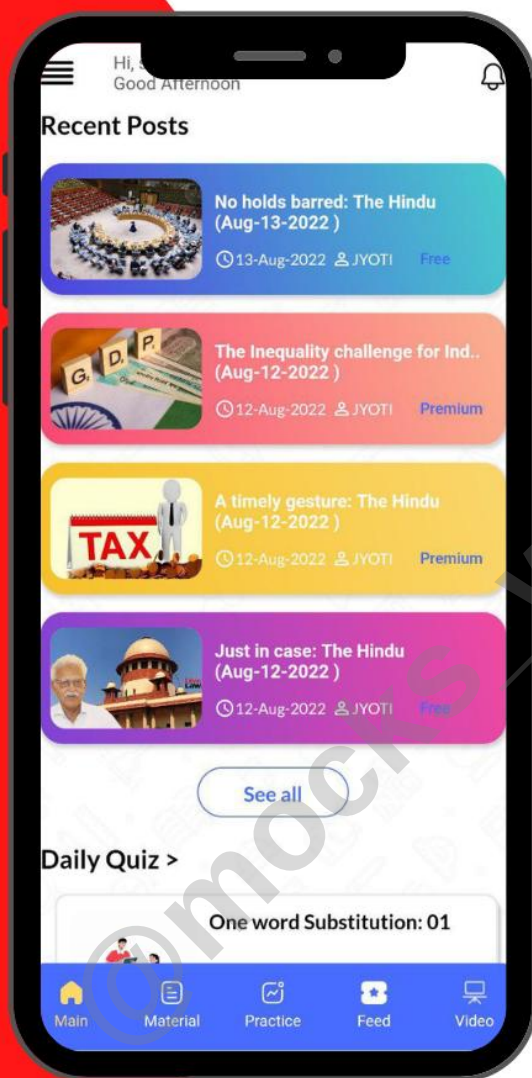
Click here to Start Quiz in the App



Click here to Start Quiz of the Editorial in the website

[Click here to download App](#)

[Click here to visit website](#)



Learn Vocabulary Through Reading Articles

English Madhyam